

3 A.M. Thoughts



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A Teen Journal for Nighttime Worry & Sleep

NORTH STAR JOURNALS

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This journal is intended for self-reflection and general well-being. It is not a substitute for professional mental-health care. If you are struggling, please reach out to a trusted adult, counselor, or crisis line. In the U.S., call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline). Outside the U.S., see findahelpline.com.

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For every worry that only shows up in the dark.

HOW TO USE THIS JOURNAL

This is your journal. Nothing in it is a test, and there is no wrong way to use it. Some pages will hit exactly right on a hard day. Others will feel like nothing. That is normal. Move on.

There are five sections inside. Grounding tools you can use in the moment, when your body is in the middle of it. Prompts to help you get the loud thoughts out of your head and onto paper, where they get a little smaller. Trackers to help you notice patterns — what triggers your anxiety, what actually helps, how sleep and mood connect. A toolkit of small practices for the hard days. And eight weeks of short reflections at the end.

You do not have to go in order. If a prompt feels wrong today, turn to another one. If a tracker doesn't fit your week, skip it. Progress is not linear, and neither is this book.

A few small suggestions:

- If your mind is loud, start with a grounding tool from Section One. Sometimes your body has to steady before your thoughts will.

- Try one prompt a day for a week, then look back. You'll see patterns you couldn't see in the moment.
- Try one tracker for a full week before deciding whether it helps. Patterns take time to show up on the page.
- Write in pencil, pen, marker, whatever. Scribble. Doodle in the margins. Leave a page half-empty. This journal will not grade you.
- If you fill a page and want more room, use one of the notes pages at the back. They're there on purpose.

One important thing: this journal is for reflection, not treatment. If your anxiety is getting in the way of school, sleep, eating, friendships, or feeling safe — please also talk to a trusted adult, a school counselor, or a mental-health professional. There are resources at the back of the book. You do not have to do this alone.

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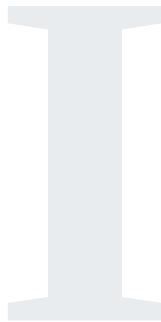
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SECTION ONE

Start Here

Five grounding tools you can use anywhere.



PRACTICE

5-4-3-2-1

A classic sensory grounding exercise. When your thoughts are racing faster than you can catch them, your senses can pull you back into your body. Take your time with each step. There is no rush.

1. Name five things you can SEE. Say them out loud or in your head.
2. Name four things you can TOUCH. Actually touch them if you can.
3. Name three things you can HEAR. Distant sounds count too.
4. Name two things you can SMELL. Or two smells you like.
5. Name one thing you can TASTE. Or one taste you'd like right now.

WHAT DID YOU NOTICE?

NOTES

PRACTICE

Box breathing

A simple breath pattern used by athletes, first responders, and anyone who needs to steady a racing nervous system. Four counts in, four hold, four out, four hold. Draw a square in the air with your finger as you go — one side per count.

1. Breathe in slowly through your nose for four counts.
2. Hold your breath gently for four counts.
3. Breathe out slowly through your mouth for four counts.
4. Hold empty for four counts. That's one full cycle.
5. Repeat four times. Notice how your body feels different at the end.

WHAT DID YOU NOTICE?

NOTES

PRACTICE

Body scan

Anxiety lives in the body — tight jaw, clenched shoulders, shallow breath. A slow scan helps you locate where you're holding it, so you can start to let it go. There is no wrong way to do this.

1. Start at the top of your head. Notice how it feels.
2. Move down slowly: forehead, jaw, neck, shoulders.
3. Continue down: chest, belly, arms, hands, hips.
4. Keep going: legs, knees, ankles, feet.
5. Where do you feel tight? Let it soften if it wants to. If it doesn't, that's okay too.

WHAT DID YOU NOTICE?

NOTES

PRACTICE

Cold water reset

A temperature shift is one of the fastest ways to interrupt an anxiety spiral. Cold on the face triggers the mammalian dive reflex, which slows your heart rate on purpose. Sounds strange. Works fast.

1. Go to a sink, or grab an ice cube or a cold drink.
2. Splash cold water on your face for 30 seconds — especially your forehead and cheeks.
3. Or: hold an ice cube in your palm until it starts to melt.
4. Or: run cold water over your wrists for 30 seconds.
5. Breathe slowly while you do it. Notice the shift.

WHAT DID YOU NOTICE?

NOTES

PRACTICE

Name it to tame it

Vague, big feelings feel unmanageable. Specific, named feelings feel smaller. Being precise about your emotion shrinks it a little and gives you something to actually work with.

1. Pause. Ask: what am I actually feeling right now?
2. Skip 'bad.' Try more specific words: anxious, angry, disappointed, embarrassed, lonely.
3. Say it out loud or write it down: 'I feel _____ because _____.'
4. See if you can name a second feeling underneath the first one.
5. Notice — did naming it change the size of it at all?

WHAT DID YOU NOTICE?

NOTES

SECTION TWO

Prompts

For the hours you are supposed to be sleeping.



NO. 01

What thought is keeping you up tonight? Write it out until it thins.

NO. 02

What did today ask of you? Write it down, so you can put it here instead of in bed.

NO. 03

What are you carrying into tonight that isn't yours to carry?

NO. 04

What time did the worry start? What were you doing? What were you not doing?

NO. 05

Write a list of everything on your mind. All of it. Then close the book.

NO. 06

What does your body need right now that it isn't getting?

Water, food, warmth, quiet?

NO. 07

What are you telling yourself about not being able to sleep? Is that true?

NO. 08

What is one thing you could do tomorrow instead of solving it tonight?

NO. 09

What is your bed like right now — safe, tense, comforting? Describe it.

NO. 10

What did today go right, even a little? Name three things.

NO. 11

What conversation from today is looping? Write the ending you wish it had.

NO. 12

What are you afraid of forgetting? Write it here so your brain can let it go.

NO. 13

What are you grateful for tonight? Something small counts.

NO. 14

What has your worry never actually solved at 3 a.m.? What has it cost you?

NO. 15

What did you do today that was hard? Take a second to notice that.

NO. 16

What is the story your brain is telling in the dark? Would you believe it in daylight?

NO. 17

What would you tell yourself in six hours if you saw yourself wide awake now?

What does 'a good enough night of sleep' look like tonight?

NO. 19

What is one comfort you can bring into bed with you? Sound, scent, warmth, memory?

NO. 20

What tomorrow-you problem is worrying you? Write a note to tomorrow-you about it.

NO. 21

What are you missing tonight? Home, a person, a version of yourself?

NO. 22

What is one thing you can let go of, just until morning?

NO. 23

What is the sound of your room right now? What if you named it out loud?

NO. 24

What is the loudest worry? Give it a name. Set it aside for the night.

NO. 25

What is the last kind thing anyone said to you? Say it back to yourself.

What did today teach you? Even one small thing.

NO. 27

What are you refusing to feel that might be part of why you can't sleep?

NO. 28

What is your morning going to need from you? Write it out, so you can rest.

NO. 29

What is a memory of feeling safe? Bring yourself back to it now, slowly.

NO. 30

Finish this: 'It is okay if tonight is not perfect. I can...'

SECTION THREE

Trackers

Notice the patterns in your sleep and nighttime worry.



TRACKER

Anxiety level this week

Rate your baseline anxiety each day. Note what set it off and what helped.

DAY	LEVEL 1-10	WHAT TRIGGERED IT	WHAT HELPED
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

TRACKER

Sleep tracker

How many hours, how well, and how you felt the next day. Patterns show up fast.

DAY	HOURS SLEPT	QUALITY 1-10	HOW I FELT
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

TRACKER

Mood check-in

Three quick check-ins each day. One word each is enough.

DAY	MORNING	AFTERNOON	NIGHT
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

TRACKER

Sleep And Nighttime Worry log

Notice when it shows up. What was happening? What did you do next?

DAY	WHEN AND WHERE	BODY FEELING	WHAT I DID NEXT
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

TRACKER

Energy this week

What drained you. What refilled you. Both matter.

DAY	LEVEL 1-10	WHAT DRAINED ME	WHAT REFILLED ME
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

TRACKER

One small win

Every day, name one small thing. Toast that wasn't burnt counts.

DAY	WIN OF THE DAY	WHO NOTICED	HOW IT FELT
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

TRACKER

Kindness to self

One kind thing you did for yourself each day. Rest counts. Naps count.

DAY	WHAT I DID	HOW IT FELT	DO AGAIN?
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

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Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

SECTION FOUR

Your Toolkit

Small practices you can return to on hard days.



PRACTICE

Worry parking

Write every worry in your head on a page. Close the book. Tell yourself: 'It will still be here in the morning if I need it.' Then close your eyes.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

The wind-down hour

Design your last hour before bed. No screens? Warm shower? Herbal tea? Book? Write the plan here, then try it for a week.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

4-7-8 breathing

Breathe in for 4 counts. Hold for 7. Breathe out for 8. Repeat four cycles. This slows your nervous system on purpose.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Progressive muscle release

Starting at your feet: squeeze the muscles for 5 seconds, then release. Move up your body — legs, belly, hands, jaw. Notice the drop.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Mental unpacking

Say out loud (or write): 'Tomorrow I will handle X. Tomorrow I will handle Y.' Give your brain permission to hand things off to future-you.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

The reset if you can't sleep

If you're wide awake after 20 minutes, get up. Go to another room. Do something low-stakes. Come back when your body is heavier.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Safe-place visualization

Bring a real or imagined safe place to mind. Water, trees, your childhood bedroom, whatever. Describe every sense: what you see, hear, smell.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

The gratitude three

Before your head hits the pillow, name three good things from today. Small counts. Toast that wasn't burnt counts.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Body scan for sleep

Starting at the top of your head, notice each part of your body and let it soften. Forehead. Jaw. Shoulders. Chest. Belly. All the way down.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Note to tomorrow-you

Write one sentence tomorrow-you needs to read first thing. Something honest and kind. Leave it on the nightstand.

TRY IT NOW.

AFFIRMATIONS

Write down phrases that feel true (or that you want to be true). Circle the ones that help most. Come back to them.

- I do not have to solve this tonight.
- Rest counts, even when I'm not asleep.
- The morning will meet me. I do not have to meet it early.
- It is okay to be awake right now.
- My body is doing its best.
- This thought can wait for daylight.
- I am safe in this bed.
- Tomorrow-me can handle tomorrow.

NOTES

SECTION FIVE

Weekly Reflections

Eight weeks of looking back and forward.



PRACTICE

Week 1 · Looking back

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 1 · Looking forward

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 2 · Looking back

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 2 · Looking forward

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 3 · Looking back

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 3 · Looking forward

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 4 · Looking back

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 4 · Looking forward

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 5 · Looking back

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 5 · Looking forward

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 6 · Looking back

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 6 · Looking forward

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 7 · Looking back

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 7 · Looking forward

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 8 · Looking back

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 8 · Looking forward

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

TRY IT NOW.

WHEN YOU NEED MORE HELP

This journal is for reflection, not treatment. If your anxiety is getting in the way of school, sleep, eating, friendships, or feeling safe, please talk to a trusted adult, a school counselor, or a therapist.

If you are in crisis:

- U.S. — Call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline).
- U.S. — Text HOME to 741741 (Crisis Text Line).
- U.K. — Call 116 123 (Samaritans).
- Global — findahelpline.com lists lines in your country.

If you or someone else is in immediate danger, call your local emergency number.

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